Lesson 1: Why was the Titanic significant to Southampton?

Summary of Lesson

Objectives:

- To make inferences from individual experiences about why the Titanic was significant to Southampton.
- To reach a well explained judgement on why the Titanic was significant to Southampton.

This is the first lesson in the scheme of work and focuses on why the Titanic mattered to Southampton at the time of its launch in 1912. Pupils will consider this by applying significance criteria to the information they gain and infer from the experiences of individuals connected to the Titanic. This lesson uses the 5 Rs significance criteria, but this can be changed to fit in with what departments and students are used to working with. The lesson begins with a brief overview of what the Titanic was the historical context. Pupils will then engage with an interactive map of Southampton, showing where passengers and crew were from in the city and whether they survived the disaster. From this, pupils can begin to discuss why the Titanic was significant. From here, pupils look at six individuals and apply the significance criteria to each experience. Students should then be able to draw on their knowledge from the lesson to reach an overall and explained judgement on why the Titanic was significant.

National Curriculum Links

This lesson links to the national curriculum aims of:

- 'understanding historical concepts such as…significance'
- 'gain historical perspective by placing their growing knowledge into different contexts, understanding the connections between local, regional, national and international history; between cultural, economic, military, political, religious and social history; and between short- and long-term timescales'.

The lesson links to the content that should be taught by being an example of 'challenges for Britain, Europe and the wider world 1901 to the present day'.

If teaching in Southampton or Hampshire, the lesson also links to the requirement of having a local history study.

Resources Required

- Lesson PowerPoint
- Significance table
- Individual experiences information

Lesson Guidance

Step 1: As this is the first lesson in the scheme of work, the lesson begins with what pupils already know about the Titanic. This is chance to gauge what knowledge pupils already have and address any misconceptions. Pupils complete a brain dump task, where they write down everything they already know. This could be done as a mind map or list in books, or pupils could write their ideas on post its and bring them to the board. There is summary video linked give students an overview, after their ideas have been shared and discussed.

Step 2: This lesson is built around the concept of significance. At this point, the criteria pupils will be working with is shared. Start with some recall of what pupils know significance to mean and where/when they have seen/applied it before in history. This lesson uses Counsell's (2005) 5Rs criteria for Historical Significance. Explain what each of these elements means to students and that they will be applying: revealed, resulted in changed and remarkable in the lesson. This lesson will work with different significance criteria so please do adapt the slides and resources should you wish to use an alternative to the 5Rs. For a higher ability group, all 5Rs could be used or the class could generate their own criteria.

Step 3: Now pupils are familiar with what the Titanic was and the significance criteria they are using, the lesson now focuses on Southampton at the time of the Titanic's launch. Slide 6 contains some brief context on Southampton in the early 20th Century. Pupils could be questioned at this point on the following:

- What does this reveal about Southampton at the time?
- Why was Southampton chosen as the port Titanic was to launch from?
- What would the launch mean for Southampton? (In terms of status, economy, opportunities for residents).

Step 4: Building on the initial context, pupils will now look at a source: an interactive map of Southampton showing where the people from the city on board the Titanic lived and what happened to them. If teaching in the city, you could look at the area that the school is in or where pupils live. This task should start to get pupils thinking about why the Titanic was significant to Southampton. Pupils could consider the following: Which parts of the city were most of the crew from? Why could this be? What would this mean for these areas? What would the large losses of life mean for these areas?

Step 5: At this point in the lesson, pupils have a chance to reflect on the lesson question and share their thoughts so far. This could be done in variety of ways, for example mini whiteboards, think pair share, post-its.

Step 6: The lesson now moves onto pupils working on the main task independently. The task builds on the thinking pupils will have done up until this point and gets them to apply the criteria revealing, resulted in change and remarkable to six induvial experiences. Each pupil will need a copy each of the significance table. This can be amended to include further prompt questions should pupils need them. Pupils are to complete the table using the six profiles. This could be done in several ways. Pupils could be given an individual each, become an expert and then move around the room sharing their individual's experiences and recording what they learn from others. The information could be put around the room and pupils move around. Or pupils could work at desks from the sheet. Below is a list of example inferences pupil might make:

- **Smith** – Southampton had a reputation as a port city, many important people from the maritime industry lived/worked there. The Titanic provided opportunities for experienced sailors. The captain being a Southampton resident would have brought pride and status to the city. As captain, Smith would have been a well-known figure and discussed in Southampton following the disaster.
- **Boxhall** – Life could be tough for people in Southampton and the Titanic offered important work and a chance to gain experience and potentially status.
- **Fleet** – There were a variety of roles on the Titanic. As the man who spotted the iceberg, Fleet would have been remarkable both nationally and locally.
- **Evans/Scarrott** - Life could be tough for people in Southampton and the Titanic offered important work and a chance to gain experience and potentially status. The loss of lives would have brought grief to local communities and put pressure on their families due to a loss of income.
- **Joughin** – The port provided work for Southampton residents from a young age. Joughin experience and unlikely survival would have been remarkable both locally and nationally.

Step 7: Pupils should now be able to reach a judgement on why the Titanic was significant to Southampton. Slide 11 has a few prompts to encourage pupils to think hard. These could be altered or removed depending on the group. This activity could be run as a discussion task or a written one, with written ideas later shared with the class, for example under a visualiser.

Step 8: If time, pupils can consider and discuss the significance of Titanic to Southampton today using the various monuments around the city as a starting point.